a group of Orthodox Jews even erected a curtain in the mixed-gender area and started conducting segregated prayers there, creating their own “facts on the ground”. Lawmakers also introduced a bill to impose criminal penalties on women who tried to read from the Torah at the Wall. Far from offering religious equality, the Knesset was contemplating whether to throw Reform Jews in jail.

Little Jew boy

A few weeks before the rabbis were warned about the Knesset, Dan Shapiro found himself on the receiving end of a different insult. The US ambassador was a popular figure in Israel, a fluent Hebrew speaker who appeared often on local television and radio. His role was often a ceremonial one: Secretary of State John Kerry and other senior officials handled the serious diplomacy, while Shapiro spent much of his time visiting schools and high-tech companies.

But he found himself staring across the intra-communal divide in early 2016 after he addressed the annual conference of the Institute for National Security Studies, a high-profile confab in Tel Aviv. His speech was mostly diplomatic boilerplate about Iran’s nuclear program and the peace process, the sort of text an ambassador reads dozens of times each year, to no real reaction. Towards the end, though, Shapiro allowed himself a few critical paragraphs. He said the State Department was “concerned and perplexed by Israel’s strategy on settlements” in the occupied West Bank. And he accused authorities of being too lax about the hundreds of anti-Palestinian attacks carried out by settlers each year. “Too many attacks on Palestinians lack a vigorous investigation or response by Israeli authorities; too much vigilantism goes unchecked; and at times there seem to be two standards of adherence to the rule of law: one for Israelis and another for Palestinians.”[8]

On the one hand, this was a simple restatement of longstanding American policy. “There’s really nothing new here in what he said,” John Kirby, the State Department spokesman, said the following afternoon.[9] Yet it was also an unusually strong statement from Shapiro. The British ambassador, no stranger to American diplomatic pablum, later called his comments “unprecedented” for a US envoy in Tel Aviv.

So he was fiercely criticized by the Israeli right—particularly by one former aide to Prime Minister Netanyahu. “It was a statement typical of a